THEATRE MANAGEMENT

Running a Theatre Company

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The organisation behind the art: governance, the season, the production calendar, contracts, and the manager's relationship with the artistic team.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- governance
- season planning
- the production calendar
- contracts
- risk

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Two jobs, one organisation

A theatre company has an artistic side, which decides what is worth making, and a management side, which decides what can be paid for. The two are not enemies; they are the same argument held in different languages. The manager's job is to make the artistic plan possible, and to say no early enough that a yes is still possible later.

Governance matters even in a student company: who signs the cheques, who can commit the company to a venue, who is responsible if something goes wrong. Write it down before the first crisis.

The season

A season is a portfolio: one production that will sell, one that will win the argument, one that trains the company, and one that is cheap. Announce the season as a whole, because audiences buy the idea of a season as much as a single play.

Balance the calendar against the institution's: examinations, holidays, the festival circuit, the availability of the hall. A brilliant production in an empty week is a loss.

The production calendar

Work backwards from opening night. Technical week, dress rehearsals, the last week of rehearsal, the build, the fittings, the design deadline, the audition, the read-through. Every date in that list is a commitment made to other people; publish it and hold it.

Build in slack for one disaster. There will be one: a lead actor leaves, the hall is double-booked, the funding does not arrive. A calendar with no slack turns a problem into a cancellation.

People, contracts and safety

Pay people if you can, and tell them early if you cannot. A written agreement - however short - should state the fee, the dates, the duties, the credit and who owns the recording. Handshake arrangements are the main cause of theatre disputes in Nigeria.

Health and safety is management's responsibility: fire exits, crowd capacity, rigging, electrical load, first aid, and a named person who can stop a performance. Insurance, where it exists, is not a substitute for a risk assessment.

The manager's week

A working week in a small company: Monday for the money (box office, invoices, payroll, the bank), Tuesday for the next production (contracts, rights, venue, designers), Wednesday for the current one (tickets, front of house, press), Thursday for people (calls, problems, the cast and crew who need an answer), Friday for the future (funding, partnerships, the season after next).

Protect one hour a day for the thing nobody else will do: reading the contracts, checking the accounts, answering the email that has been waiting. Management fails slowly, through the letters that were not answered.

Write a weekly one-page report to the board or the head of department: what happened, what it cost, what is coming, what you need. A manager who reports regularly is trusted with the crisis; a manager who reports only in a crisis is blamed for it.

The company meeting

Hold one meeting a week, with an agenda, a time limit and written minutes. Three standing items: what is happening this week, what is at risk, and what needs a decision today. Everything else goes in a note.

Minutes matter more than meetings. They are the record of who agreed to what, they protect the manager when a decision is questioned, and they are the institutional memory that survives the graduating class. Circulate them within a day, while people still remember disagreeing.

Exercises

1. Write a one-page governance memorandum for a student company: who decides, who signs, who is accountable.
2. Plan a four-production season with a stated budget, a venue and an audience for each.
3. Draw a production calendar backwards from opening night and mark where you have built in slack.

Where to read more

Colley Cibber, An Apology for the Life of Mr. Colley Cibber (1740)

Brander Matthews, A Book About the Theater (1916)

Iain Mackintosh, Architecture, Actor and Audience (1993)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.